

Google introduces new ad setting as audit flags opt-out gaps

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By [Maria Dinzeo](#)

Google has introduced a new setting allowing users to limit how their data is shared with advertising partners across third-party websites and apps, after a recent audit raised questions about whether major ad tech companies are honoring browser-based opt-out signals.

Google on Friday notified its users, via an early morning email, of a new setting allowing them to opt out of personalized ads on partner sites and apps, a change the company said is designed to give people more control over how their data is shared with advertising partners across the web.

“At Google, we believe you should always be in control of your data. That’s why we’ve built My Ad Center and many Google Account tools, like Privacy Checkup, that make it easy to manage your data, privacy and security settings,” said an email from Google Ads. “Building on these controls, we’re introducing a new setting through Google Partner ad settings that lets you choose whether to provide additional information to advertising partners when you visit websites and apps that partner with Google.”

Google said this data allows the news sites, retailers and app developers that use Google’s ad products to select which ads to show consumers and measure their performance.

The rollout comes as a recent independent audit raised questions about whether the world’s largest digital advertising companies are effectively honoring consumer opt-out requests (see [here](#)).

A Google spokesperson told MLex: “People have many tools to control how their information is used for advertising with Google, and we’re expanding those options even further.”

The company didn’t directly address whether the new feature was related to the audit’s findings.

The audit, put out by research firm webXray, found that ad tech tools from Google, Meta and Microsoft continued to set tracking identifiers on users even after browsers sent an opt-out signal known as Global Privacy Control.

Researchers reviewed more than 7,000 popular websites and found Google failed to honor users’ opt-out choices in 87 percent of cases despite receiving the signal, followed by Meta at 69 percent and Microsoft at 50 percent.

All three companies disputed the audit’s findings in statements to MLex.

Global Privacy Control is a browser-based tool that allows consumers to opt out of the sale or sharing of their personal information, and California privacy rules require businesses to treat those signals as valid opt-out requests.

On LinkedIn, Timothy Libert, a former Google privacy engineer who left the company in 2023 and founded webXray, remarked on the timing of Google’s launch. “I look forward to verifying this new feature works as stated, at scale, in the next installment of Global Privacy Audit,” he said.

WebXray’s findings come amid increased scrutiny by California regulators of whether opt-out mechanisms function as intended (see [here](#)). The California Department of Justice fined digital wellness platform Healthline Media \$1.55 million last year because its opt-out mechanism didn’t work correctly when investigators tested it (see [here](#)).

California privacy agency CalPrivacy also fined Tractor Supply \$1.35 million for the same failure, among other alleged violations of the California Consumer Privacy Act (see [here](#)).

California’s privacy enforcer CalPrivacy did not respond to a request for comment from MLex on the webXray audit.

Asked about the report, the California Department of Justice declined to comment on any potential investigation but said it continues to enforce the state’s privacy law.

“While we’re unable to comment on, even to confirm or deny, potential or ongoing investigations to protect their integrity,

the California Department of Justice continues to actively enforce the CCPA and advance the protection of our residents' privacy rights," a spokesperson said. "While we cannot comment on the specific issues raised by the report, we always welcome reporting about potential CCPA violations — anyone interested in reporting a potential violation to our office can go to oag.ca.gov/report."

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